

Dhirubhai Ambani Institute of Information and Communication Technology

Elective Course: Debating Right and Wrong in the Mahabharata: Style and Context

An Elective Course for the Senior Undergraduate Students of the BTech ICT program

Course Format: 3 Credits. 3 Lectures per week.

Prerequisites: None

Course Content: The gripping heroic narrative of the Mahabharata also contains a vast number of subsidiary stories and discussions, which together reflect the entire range of human emotions and situations, while debating the nature of right and wrong, both in the context of immediate human situations and the overarching philosophy of life. This essential debate over right and wrong, presented in different forms within the epic, above all in the Bhagavad Gita, might be the main reason for the epic to be regarded variously as a treatise on ethics and metaphysics (dharmashastra), a repository of the highest knowledge (the fifth veda), a guide to right action (itihasa), and the human condition itself. The epic transforms the account of a usual rivalry and battle between two groups of the same family onto a plane that lends universality, symbolic power, and ethical relevance to its narrative.

The discussions and episodes of the epic primarily involve the question of the ultimate goal of human life, emphasised in the epic yet again in its closing section: that of the question of right and wrong. The narrative contains such episodes that may make the reader doubt whether the Mahabharata is a moral text. The human dilemmas are at places so acute and familiar as to evoke sympathy for immoral characters. It might be pointed out that Dharma, as in the philosophical universe of the Mahabharata, is a means and an end in itself. The Mahabharata does not advocate a withdrawal from life but a participation in life according to the norms of dharma without undue attachment to those aspects of life commonly or primarily experienced through sensory perception. Action can be considered as emerging from desire. Desire in the present course of action is not meant merely as wish or bodily urge, but the mental impulse to perform action, when the performer becomes an agent, or a means of action which has an objective. But the definition of desire is problematic. Is it always ethical and altruistic? Or completely self-centred? Does a impulse which is completely self-centric actually always serves the self? What is the self, for instance?

This definition of desire might not convey an easy and uncomplicated path, but the concept of dharma has never been expected to present easy options for its observance. If we proceed with the premise that dharma is in a sense an objective, the fundamental objective no doubt, but an objective nevertheless, the state of being dharmic does not alone lead to liberation, as identification in life with the practice of dharma retains the self within the play of *gunas* or the three composite qualities of life. The observance of dharma, it can be argued, is only possible with an attitude of detachment. For the Mahabharata, it is therefore not enough for Yudhishtira, the dharma king, to have throughout his life observed dharma in exactness; he must in the end forsake his identification with the observance of dharma to attain the ultimate realisation of the self, that of liberation of the soul.

An ethical dilemma might not necessarily undermine ethical ideas. They source the existential strength of the epic insofar as the demonstration of the resilience of difficult situations regarding ethics and virtue is concerned. With all the inequality and injustice that have characterised social systems across time, the epic seems to suggest that such seeming resilience of reality to ideals reinforces the validity of ideals, particularly on the individual plane. Some prominent scholars tracing the changing form of the Mahabharata over the early centuries of its existence, point out that after the period of its earliest development through an oral tradition practised by singer-poets, the Bhrigu clan became its custodians for the most extended duration. While forming its present shape and volume, they took particular interest in incorporating the subjects of dharma (law) and niti (conduct), which were their unique preserve, mainly in the Santi and Anushasana parvas of the epic. This explains the profound emphasis laid on the two subjects throughout the epic.

The course will involve detailed readings of some chapters of the Mahabharata and Bhagavad Gita, as well as discussion and presentation of the fundamental questions in those chapters regarding right and wrong. The course will concentrate mainly on the following topics:

- The main features of the Narration of the Mahabharata
- The story of the epic
- Certain complicated ethical issues, such as the destiny of Karna; the anxiety of Amba/Shikhandi; the Injustice to Ekalavya; the marriage of Draupadi; and the episode of the game of dice

- The short conversation between Yudhishtira and the Yaksha
- The theme of the *Bhagavad Gita*
- The Imagery of the two trees – those of Dharma and Adharma
- The Ethical Lapses of the Mahabharata War
- The question of Non-Violence in the Mahabharata
- Pain, Truth and Eternal Relevance of the Mahabharata
- The Final Journey of the Pandavas from Earth

Primary Readings:

Ganguli, K. M. 2007. Trans. The *Mahabharata*. 12 vols. New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal.
[Relevant Chapters.]

[All readings will be provided electronically before the commencement of the course.]

Recommended Readings:

Chakrabarti, Shirshendu. 2016. 'Irresolution and Agency: The Case of Yudhishtira', Ed. Bhattacharya S.C., Vrinda Dalmiya & Mukherji Gangeya. *Exploring Agency in the Mahabharata: Ethical and Political Dimensions of Dharma*. Oxon; New Delhi: Routledge. pp. 129-42.

Chaturvedi, Badrinath. 2007. 'Ahimsa –Not-Violence, the Foundation of Life', *The Mahabharata: An Inquiry in the Human Condition*. New Delhi: Orient Longman. pp. 113-168.

Chaturvedi, Badrinath. 2007. 'Introduction to the Mahabharata', *The Mahabharata: An Inquiry in the Human Condition*. New Delhi: Orient Longman. pp. 1-22.

Chaturvedi, Badrinath. 2007. 'The Question of Truth', *The Mahabharata: An Inquiry in the Human Condition*. New Delhi: Orient Longman. pp. 181-98.

Iyengar, K.R. Srinivas. 2017. 'The Mahabharata: An Epic of Universality and Deep Human Concern' in Ed. Dandekar, R.N. *The Mahabharata Revisited*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. pp. 169-182.

Jani, A.N. 1989. 'The Socio-Moral Implications of Draupadi's Marriage to Five Husbands', Ed. Matilal, Bimal Krishna. *Moral Dilemmas in the Mahabharata*. Shimla; New Delhi: IIAS; Motilal Banarsidass. pp. 69-76.

Jani, A.N. 2017. 'The Mahabharata as an Organic Growth of the Oral Tradition in Ancient India', Ed. Dandekar, R.N. *The Mahabharata Revisited*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. pp. 71-85.

Joshi, Umashankar. 2017. 'A Creative Writer's View of the Mahabharata', Ed. Dandekar, R.N. *The Mahabharata Revisited*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. pp. 281-289.

Lath, Mukund. 2017. 'The Concept of anrsamsya in the Mahabharata', Ed. Dandekar, R.N. *The Mahabharata Revisited*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. pp. 113-119.

Mishra, Vidya Nivas. *Mahabharata ka Kavyarth*. Delhi: National Publishing House.

Mukherji, Gangeya. 2016. 'Complexities in the Agency for Violence: A Look at the Mahabharata', Ed. Bhattacharya S.C., Vrinda Dalmiya & Mukherji Gangeya. *Exploring Agency in the*

Mahabharata: Ethical and Political Dimensions of Dharma. Oxon; New Delhi: Routledge. pp. 109-28.

Pande, G.C. 2017. 'The Socio-Cultural Milieu of the Mahabharata', Ed. Dandekar, R.N. *The Mahabharata Revisited*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. pp. 121-137.

Raja, Kunjunni. K. 1989. 'A Note on the Moral Dilemmas in the Mahabharata', Ed. Matilal, Bimal Krishna. *Moral Dilemmas in the Mahabharata*. Shimla; New Delhi: IIAS; Motilal Banarsidass. pp. 49-52.

Sarukkai, Sundar. 2016. 'Eklavya and the Possibility of Learning', Ed. Bhattacharya S.C., Vrinda Dalmiya & Mukherji Gangeya. *Exploring Agency in the Mahabharata: Ethical and Political Dimensions of Dharma*. Oxon; New Delhi: Routledge. pp. 179-94.

Suthankar, V.S. 1998. *The Meaning of the Mahabharata*. New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers.

LEARNING OUTCOMES: The course aims to acquaint students with the narrative and themes of the Mahabharata and invites them to think critically about the complex issues of pain, untruth, violence, compassion, and equanimity. It will also familiarise them with different approaches to reading texts by examining various textual devices, identifying their central arguments, and raising questions that may arise from individual perspectives.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Attendance and Participation: The success of the course depends significantly on students' engagement with the readings and with one another in class.

Mode of Teaching: The course will be divided into three broad modules. The first module will focus on the Narration of the Mahabharata, the epic story, and specific complicated ethical issues, such as Karna's destiny, Amba/Shikhandi's anxiety, Ekalavya's injustice, Draupadi's marriage, and the episode of the dice game. The second module will comprise the study of the short conversation between Yudhishtira and the Yaksha, the theme of the Bhagavad Gita, the imagery of the two trees – those of Dharma and Adharma - and the issue of ethical lapses in the Mahabharata War. The third module will focus on the question of Non-Violence in the Mahabharata, exploring aspects of pain, truth, and the eternal essence of the Mahabharata, as well as the final journey of the Pandavas from Earth.

EVALUATION: The first evaluation, comprising multiple-choice questions from the first module, will account for 30% of the total marks and will be conducted as part of the mid-semester examinations. Student presentations scheduled for the last week of October, and centred around the second module, will account for another 10% of the marks. The students are encouraged to make presentations based on their personal interpretation on the topics, as well as the adaptations of the epi or its episodes in tele serials and contemporary retellings. The end-semester examination, comprising multiple-choice, short-answer, and one detailed-answer

question, will cover the entire course with a focus on the third module and account for 60% of the marks.

PLAGIARISM AND ACADEMIC INTEGRITY: Using words and phrases of authors without proper citation is considered a violation of norms of academic integrity and is strictly discouraged. Genuine effort and commitment will be duly appreciated.

COURSE OUTCOMES The course aims to achieve the following outcomes, apart from the ones stated above:

- Understanding the broader ethical, human responsibility of overriding importance while approaching scientific and technical challenges relating to building amenities and individual and corporate wealth.
- Efforts will be made during the course to correlate concepts from western philosophy, but this will not constitute an extensive exercise. The course is not an exercise in philosophy in general, or western philosophy in particular, but is centred on a particular Indian tradition of ethics and argument, and the frequent challenges raised to it by modern discourses on entitlement, equality, hierarchy, exclusion and power. These issues are adequately covered in specific topics marked for particular attention. Moreover, the Mahabharata has been the subject of a host of interpretations and it is not possible to take on board, a miniscule variety, let alone a representative selection. This unwieldy variety of interpretations goes towards contributing to the attractiveness and longevity of epics.
- The Mahabharata provides us with a deep understanding of life's complicated realities, and regards life as a continuous dedication to ethical purpose that is simultaneously individual and collective. To serve a social purpose and uplift the individual soul, every person needs to make complex moral choices, with easy options often unavailable.
- Debating right and wrong is an ever-continuous human characteristic, and embarking on the right course of action is almost always tricky. The course will highlight the importance of this demanding and exciting exercise of distinguishing between the correct choice and the merely attractive one, as well as the importance of due diligence in acting on the proper course of action in various situations of material existence.
